The Cask of Amontillado

By Edgar Allan Poe

INTRODUCTION

The thousand injuries of Fortunato I had borne as I best could but when he ventured upon insult I vowed revenge you who so well know the nature of my soul will not suppose however that gave utterance to a threat at length I would be avenged this was a point definitely settled but the very definitiveness with which it was resolved precluded the idea of risk I must not only punish but punish with impunity a wrong is un-redressed when retribution overtakes its redresser it is equally un-redressed when the avenger fails to make himself felt as such to him who has done the wrong. The Cask of Amontillado by Edgar Allan Poe

It must be understood that neither by word nor deed had I given Fortunato cause to doubt my good will I continued as was my in to smile in his face and he did not perceive that my to smile now was at the thought of his immolation

He had a weak point this Fortunato although in other regards he was a man to be respected and even feared he prided himself on his connoisseurship in wine few

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Italians have the true virtuoso spirit for the most part their enthusiasm is adopted to suit the time and opportunity to practice imposture upon the British and Austrian millionaires in painting and gemmary Fortunato like his countrymen was a quack but in the matter of old wines he was sincere in this respect I did not differ from him materially I was skillful in the Italian vintages myself, and bought largely whenever I could

It was about dusk one evening during the supreme madness of the carnival season that I encountered my friend he accosted me with excessive warmth for he had been drinking much the man wore motley he had on a tight-fitting party-striped dress and his head was surmounted by the conical cap and bells I was so pleased to see him that I thought I should never have done wringing his hand

I said to him "my dear Fortunato you are luckily met how remarkably well you are looking today but I have received a pipe of what passes for Amontillado and I have my doubts"

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"How?" said he "Amontillado a pipe? Impossible and in the middle of the carnival"

"I have my doubts" I replied "and I was silly enough to pay the full Amontillado price without consulting you in the matter you were not to be found and I was fearful of losing a bargain" "Come let us go"

"Whither?"

"To your vaults"

"My friend no"

"Let us go nevertheless the cold is merely nothing"

Thus speaking Fortunato possessed himself of my arm and putting on a mask of black silk and drawing a roquelaire closely about my person I suffered him to hurry me to my palazzo. I took from their sconces two flambeaux and giving one to Fortunato bowed him through several suites of rooms to the archway that led into the vaults we came at length to the foot of the descent and stood together upon the damp ground of the catacombs of the Montresors

The gait of my friend was unsteady and the bells upon his cap jingled as he strode

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"The pipe" he said

"It is farther on" said I "but observe the white web-work which gleams from these walls" He turned towards me and looked into my eves with two filmy orbs that distilled the rheum of intoxication

"Nitre?" he asked at length

"Nitre" I replied. "How long have you had that cough?"

"Ugh ugh ugh ugh ugh " My poor friend found it impossible to reply for many minutes

"It is nothing" he said, at last

"Come" I said with decision "we will go back your health is precious you are rich respected admired beloved you are happy as once I was you are a man to be missed for me it is no matter we will go back you will be ill and I cannot be responsible Besides there is Luchresi "

"Enough" he said "the cough's a mere nothing it will not kill me I shall not die of a cough"

"True, true" I replied "and indeed I had no intention of alarming you unnecessarily but you should use all proper caution a draught of this Medoc will defend us from the damps

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Here I knocked off the neck of a bottle which I drew from a long row of its fellows that lay upon the mould "Drink" I said presenting him the wine. He raised it to his lips with a leer he paused and nodded to me familiarly while his bells jingled

"I drink" he said "to the buried that repose around us"

"And I to your long life" He again took my arm and we proceeded

"These vaults" he said, "are extensive"

"The Montresors" I replied "were a great and numerous family"

"I forget your arms"

"A huge human foot d'or in a field azure the foot crushes a serpent rampant whose fangs are imbedded in the heel"

"And the motto?"

"Nemo me impune lacessit"

"Good" he said. The wine sparkled in his eyes and the bells jingled as my own fancy grew warm with the Medoc we had passed through long walls of piled skeletons with casks and puncheons intermingling into the inmost

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recesses of the catacombs I paused again and this time I made bold to seize Fortunato by an arm above the elbow.

"The nitre!" I said "see it increases It hangs like moss upon the vaults we are below the river's bed the drops of moisture trickle among the bones come we will go back ere it is too late your cough "

"It is nothing" he said "let us go on but first another draught of the Medoc" I broke and reached him a flagon of De Grave he emptied it at a breath his eyes flashed with a fierce light he laughed and threw the bottle upwards with a gesticulation I did not understand. I looked at him in surprise he repeated the movement a grotesque one

"You do not comprehend?" he said

"Not I" I replied

"Then you are not of the brotherhood"

"How?"

"You are not of the masons"

"Yes, yes" I said; "yes, yes"

"You? Impossible a mason?"

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"A mason" I replied.

"A sign" he said "a sign"

"It is this" I answered producing from beneath the folds of my roquelaire a trowel

"You jest" he exclaimed recoiling a few paces "But let us proceed to the Amontillado."

"Be it so" I said replacing the tool beneath the cloak and again offering him my arm he leaned upon it heavily we continued our route in search of the Amontillado we passed through a range of low arches descended passed on and descending again arrived at a deep crypt in which the foulness of the air caused our flambeaux rather to glow than flame at the most remote end of the crypt there appeared another less spacious its walls had been lined with human remains, piled to the vault overhead, in the fashion of the great catacombs of Paris three sides of this interior crypt were still ornamented in this manner from the fourth side the bones had been thrown down and lay promiscuously upon the earth forming at one point a mound of some size within the wall thus exposed by the displacing of the bones we perceived a

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still interior crypt or recess in depth about four feet in width three in height six or seven it seemed to have been constructed for no especial use within itself but formed merely the interval between two of the colossal supports of the roof of the catacombs and was backed by one of their circumscribing walls of solid granite it was in vain that Fortunato uplifting his dull torch endeavored to pry into the depth of the recess its termination the feeble light did not enable us to see.

"Proceed" I said "herein is the Amontillado as for Luchresi"

"He is an ignoramus" interrupted my friend as he stepped unsteadily forward while I followed immediately at his heels in niche and finding an instant he had reached the extremity of the niche and finding his progress arrested by the rock stood stupidly bewildered a moment more and I had fettered him to the granite in its surface were two iron staples distant from each other about two feet horizontally from one of these depended a short chain from the other a padlock

Throwing the links about his waist it was but the work

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of a few seconds to secure it he was too much astounded to resist withdrawing the key I stepped back from the recesses

As I said these words I busied myself among the pile of bones of which I have before spoken throwing them aside I soon uncovered a quantity of building stone and mortar with these materials and with the aid of my trowel I began vigorously to wall up the entrance of the niche a succession of loud and shrill screams bursting suddenly from the throat of the chained form seemed to thrust me violently back for a brief moment I hesitated I trembled unsheathing my rapier I began to grope with it about the recess but the thought of an instant reassured me I placed my hand upon the solid fabric of the catacombs and felt satisfied I re-approached the wall

I replied to the yells of him who clamored I re-echoed I aided I surpassed them in volume and in strength I did this and the clamorer grew still

It was now midnight and my task was drawing to a close I had completed the eighth the ninth and the tenth tier

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I had finished a portion of the last and the eleventh there remained but a single stone to be fitted and plastered in I struggled with its weight I placed it partially in its destined position but now there came from out the niche a low laugh that erected the hairs upon my head it was succeeded by a sad voice which I had difficulty in recognizing as that of the noble Fortunato The voice said "Ha ha ha he he he a very good joke indeed an excellent jest we will have many a rich laugh about it at the palazzo he he he over our wine he he he"

"The Amontillado" I said

"He he he he he he yes the Amontillado but is it not getting late? Will not they be awaiting us at the palazzo the Lady Fortunato and the rest let us be gone"

"Yes" I said "let us be gone"

"For the love of God Montresor"

"Yes" I said "for the love of God" But to these words I hearkened in vain for a reply I grew impatient I called aloud "Fortunato"

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No answer I called again "Fortunato" No answer still. I thrust a torch through the remaining aperture and let it fall within. There came forth in return only a jingling of the bells my heart grew sick it was the dampness of the catacombs that made it so. I hastened to make an end of my labour I forced the last stone into its position I plastered it up against the new masonry I re-erected the old rampart of bones for the half of a century no mortal has disturbed them

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